The Prescott Girls - Study Guide

Beckie Prescott's Sampler (1835)

Artifact Overview

Maker: Rebecca Goodwin Johnson Prescott
Age at completion: Eight years old
Date: 1835
Location: Dresden, Maine
Materials: Silk thread on linen
Dimensions: 16½ inches wide × 17 inches high

This sampler was stitched by Rebecca Goodwin Johnson Prescott, known in her family as **Beckie**, when she was eight years old. Today it survives as both a piece of needlework and a historical record of a young girl's education, family, and beliefs in early nineteenth-century Maine.

When the sampler was rediscovered at auction in California, it had been **stitched together along a deteriorated vertical fold line**, which had partially obscured some of the embroidery. After careful study, the design elements and inscriptions could be reconstructed and interpreted.

What Is a Sampler?

In the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, girls often stitched **samplers** as part of their education. A sampler served several purposes:

- It was a **practice piece** for learning embroidery stitches.
- It demonstrated a girl's **literacy and numeracy**, often including alphabets and numbers.
- It reflected **moral or religious instruction**, frequently featuring Bible verses or sayings.
- It served as a **record of identity**, including the maker's name, age, and date.

Samplers were often displayed in the home and preserved by families for generations.

Design Elements of Beckie's Sampler

Border

The sampler includes a decorative stitched border framing the work. Borders were common in school samplers and helped demonstrate control and precision in stitching.

Alphabets

Alphabet rows appear on the sampler. These were important exercises for girls learning needlework because they practiced:

- letter formation
- spacing
- consistency in stitching

Alphabet samplers also allowed girls to later **mark household linens and clothing** with initials.

Numerals

Beckie included **numbers 1 through 10**, another typical teaching exercise. Numbers were often used to teach counting as well as stitching repetition.

Location and Date

The sampler includes the inscription:

“Dresden Maine 1835”

Including the location was somewhat less common than including the date, and it provides a valuable historical clue about where Beckie was living when the sampler was completed.

Maker’s Inscription

The sampler identifies the maker:

“Rebecca G J Prescott aged eight years”

It was common for girls to include their name and age to mark the accomplishment of finishing the piece.

Moral Verse

The sampler also includes a version of the well-known moral teaching often called the **Golden Rule**:

“Do unto others as you (possible missing word) would that others unto you should do.”

The missing word may have originally been **“would,”** a common phrasing in nineteenth-century versions of the verse.

This principle appears in many religious traditions and was frequently taught to children as a guiding rule for behavior.

The Girl Who Made the Sampler

Rebecca Goodwin Johnson Prescott was born **March 24, 1827, in New Sharon, Maine**. She was the oldest daughter of:

Warren Prescott, a schoolteacher
Rebecca Johnson Prescott, who also made a sampler preserved from this same family.

Beckie had two younger sisters:

- **Caroline Louisa Prescott 'Louisa'**
- **Sarah Augusta Prescott 'Sallie'**

When Beckie was six years old, tragedy struck the family. In **1833**, her father drowned in the **upper Kennebec River** after falling through the ice.

Following his death, Beckie's mother moved the family back to her childhood home, the **Old Court House in Dresden, Maine**. There they lived with Rebecca's brothers:

- **Thomas Johnson**, the Dresden postmaster
- **William Johnson**, Managed the family property

The courthouse had become the Johnson family home, and several branches of the family lived there together.

Connections to a Larger American Story

The Prescott family had connections reaching far beyond rural Maine.

Another of Rebecca Johnson Prescott's brothers was **Captain Rowland Johnson**, a sea captain. He and his wife Nancy later moved to **Philadelphia**, where Rowland worked as a grocer.

Because yellow fever outbreaks were common in Philadelphia during the summer, Beckie and her sisters often traveled between **Maine and Philadelphia** while growing up.

Through these family ties, the Prescott sisters became connected to the family of **Betsy Ross**.

Beckie's sister **Caroline Louisa Prescott** later married **William Jackson Canby**, Betsy Ross's grandson. In 1870, William Canby's public lecture about his grandmother helped shape the famous story of Betsy Ross sewing the first American flag.

Beckie's Later Life

Rebecca Prescott never married. By the late 1850s she was being courted by a mariner named **David or Daniel Reed**, but evidence suggests he may have died while at sea.

Rebecca instead devoted her life to **teaching**, following in the footsteps of her father.

Historical records show her living in several places throughout her life:

- **1860 — Dresden, Maine**
- **1865 — Philadelphia**
- **1870 and 1880 — Philadelphia**, living with her sister Louisa and brother-in-law William Canby

Later in life she returned to Maine.

Rebecca Prescott died **April 9, 1906**, and is buried in the **Old Court House Cemetery in Dresden**, not far from the building where she stitched her sampler more than seventy years earlier.

Why This Sampler Matters

Beckie's sampler is valuable for several reasons:

It records the work of an eight-year-old girl in 1835.

It connects three generations of women in the same family, since Beckie's mother also made a sampler.

It reflects the education of girls in early America, combining needlework, literacy, and moral teaching.

It links the Prescott family to the wider story of the Betsy Ross family and early American history.

Most importantly, the sampler preserves the voice of a child from nearly two centuries ago. In the careful stitches of silk on linen, Beckie left behind a record of her learning, her family, and the values that shaped her life.

Questions for Discussion

1. Why do you think girls were taught embroidery as part of their education in the 1800s?

2. What does the inclusion of alphabets and numbers tell us about how children learned in the nineteenth century?

3. Why might Beckie have included the Golden Rule on her sampler?

4. How do objects like samplers help historians understand everyday life in the past?

5. Beckie was only eight years old when she completed this work. What does that tell us about the skills children were expected to learn at that age?